

Mission and Target Audience



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Mission

We're on a mission to support our students (especially those marginalized by gender, race, and/or age) to learn in-demand tech skills and land higher paying and more fulfilling jobs.

We have a strong commitment to inclusivity and combating barriers people face in tech, rooted in the belief that *tech is for everyone* and that belonging should be felt from the very first step of the journey.

Target Audience

We aim to support learners from groups like women, BIPOC, LGBTQ+ people, people with disabilities, career changers, those without college degrees, and parents or caregivers as they move from total tech newbie to tech pro.

Skillcrush's audience is largely made up of people who are interested in learning tech skills but are held back by real life, practical, and career-related barriers.

Our target audience pain points include:

- Feeling intimidated by tech:

- Many prospective learners want a tech career but feel overwhelmed by jargon, complexity, and the myth that you must be a “natural” or have a CS degree. They worry they won’t “get it.”
- Lack of experience:
 - Their audience often comes in with little to no background in technology or coding—no CS classes, bootcamp experience, or tech job history.
- Career uncertainty:
 - Learners want to enter tech, but are unsure which roles fit them, what jobs are realistic without a degree, and which skills translate to real income
- Financial and time constraints:
 - Many in Skillcrush’s audience are juggling bills and financial pressure, work or caregiving responsibilities, limited time for learning
- Feeling isolated or excluded:
 - A big part of Skillcrush’s audience has felt excluded from tech because of gender norms, racial or cultural stereotypes, lack of representation, and imposter syndrome
- Difficulty choosing where to start:
 - Tech is huge (web dev, UX design, data analytics, marketing tech, etc.). Beginners often are unsure what path to take or what skills to learn first

Our target audience needs:

- Help learning new marketable and relevant tech skills
- Guidance on what skills are in demand to open doors to new career opportunities
- Better job/career prospects
- Clarity, simple explanations, and confidence-building support to learn without any previous knowledge of jargon or technical prerequisite.
- A supportive and friendly learning environment/community that understands their lived experience

Types of writing

Familiar

Messages that are more familiar are ones that are written as if you’re close friends with the reader and have known each other for years. They’re generally more personal, targeted, or nurture-based, and they usually tell some sort of a story as a way to connect 1-on-1 with the reader. They also may rely on data the user has volunteered to us through mass surveys or directly through email, so they tend to be very specific.

Examples include:

- Emails sent to our newsletter list

Non-familiar

Non-familiar messages are generally less specific and more salesy in nature. Though they're still framed as if you're writing to a close friend, the messages are focused more on getting the subject matter across and potentially creating a sense of urgency — and less on nurturing and storytelling (though these elements may still be included).

Examples include:

- Sales announcements and reminder emails

Emotional

Emotional messages are messages that connect with readers through their sentiments or feelings. These messages usually involve storytelling in order to make a strong emotional impact and connection. Emotional messages are generally found in our sales emails and on social media.

Examples include:

- [Day In the Life blogs](#)
- [Non-technical blog posts](#)

Non-emotional

Messages that are less emotional are ones that are used to strictly share knowledge. They're less focused on storytelling and more focused on getting information across. These types of messages can be found in our newsletters and in certain blog posts.

Examples include:

- [Technical "how to" blog posts](#)
- [Technical insight blog posts](#)

Writing Style Guide



Writing Style Guide



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Voice & Tone

Skillcrush's voice is friendly, empowering, and overall HUMAN. We want to sound like a knowledgeable friend who genuinely wants learners to succeed. We do not want to sound like a tech bro, not a stuffy academic, or condescending.

We believe tech is for EVERYONE and learning tech skills should feel possible, welcoming, and even fun.

Our tone is:

- Warm and encouraging
- Conversational and approachable

- Clear, confident, and beginner-friendly
- Inclusive and values-driven
- Practical, not preachy
- Occasionally playful, never flippant

When in doubt, ask yourself: *Would this make a nervous beginner feel supported and capable?*

Additional context

We try to be approachable, honest, and lighthearted in our copy. Which means we:

- Break down complicated concepts into digestible pieces
 - Understand our audience's fears and goals
 - Are earnest and sincere with our advice to beginners in tech, and never flippant (although we sometimes try to be funny!)
 - Aim to make it FUN to learn digital skills and make a career change
 - Serious about tech education but not ourselves ;)
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General Writing Guidelines

1) Be beginner-first

Assume your reader is smart but new. Avoid jargon when possible, and explain it clearly when you can't.

✗ "Leverage semantic HTML for improved accessibility"

✓ "Use semantic HTML (HTML elements that describe their purpose) to make your site more accessible."

2) Be clear and concrete

Write what you mean. Choose clarity over cleverness.

✗ "Unlock your professional potential"

✓ "Learn skills that help you get hired for entry-level tech roles"

3) Be encouraging, not intimidating

Tech can feel scary. Your job is to lower the barrier, not raise it.

- Avoid gatekeeping language
- Normalize confusion and learning curves
- Celebrate progress over perfection

4) Be actionable

Readers should leave knowing **what to do next**.

- Include steps, examples, or resources whenever possible
- Always include quiz or Camp Skillcrush CTAs

5) Guide the reader

Structure content like a supportive learning journey.

- Preview what's coming ("First, we'll cover...")
- Use clear transitions
- End with a takeaway or next step

Vocabulary/Grammar

1) Language standards

- Use standard American English
- For general questions about grammar, reference the [AP Stylebook Guide](#)

2) Headings

- Headlines, subheadings, and larger supporting copy should use Title Case
 - How to Become a Web Developer Without a CS Degree
- Headlines and subheadings should be brief and never more than one sentence long
- Event names should always be in Title Case
 - Best AI Tools for Designers
- Body copy should follow sentence style capitalization

3) Inclusive language

- Skillcrush is explicitly inclusive

- Avoid gendered language (“guys,” “manpower”)
- Avoid ableist or exclusionary phrases (“crazy,” “blind spot,” “sanity check”)
- Use people-first language when relevant
- Refer to [PowerToFly’s Inclusive Language Guidelines](#) when talking specifically about or to individuals of a certain identity.

4) Conversational language

- We’re NOT about making ourselves seem perfect or overly aspirational. We believe in real talk and being as specific as possible.
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- We aim to speak plainly and conversationally with as few uses of tech jargon as possible.
Examples that fit our voice:
 - “You’ve got this”
 - “Let’s break it down”
 - “Here’s the good news”
 - “That’s totally normal”
- We do use figures of speech, but try to avoid cliches.
- We’re positive, but not ridiculously so. We do love ourselves a good exclamation point, but we do our best to know when we’ve added enough!
- And we always love some good wordplay. We’re nerds afterall.
- We are real people and do draw on our own experiences in copy when possible.
- We’re honest and real. Learning tech skills isn’t always going to be easy. Landing a job will take work. Our classes aren’t a magic pill, and we don’t use language that implies they are. But we do use language that inspires confidence so our students feel inspired to do the hard work that’s necessary.

5) Acronyms

- Spell out acronyms on first mention, followed by the acronym in parentheses
- Common exceptions: HTML, CSS, CEO, UX

6) Always cite the facts

- Most of the time, just a link to the referenced material should do, as long as the source is credible. (See also our guidance on anchor links below.)

7) Other grammar specifications:

- Embrace the [Oxford Comma](#)
- Emojis are 🍌 if used sparingly, and intended to be taken literally. Avoid using emojis that show skin color unless using multiple versions to show all skin colors.
- Spell out numbers one through nine, use numerals for 10 and above. E.g. Nine questions, 10 posts.

- Exception: If it's a range, use numerals. Ex. "1 to 9"
- Exception: If the number (including years) starts the sentence, spell it out. E.g. "Forty-five percent ..."
- Exception: In titles, headers, and subheaders, use numerals
- Try to avoid using the em dash with spaces (—). Instead, use a colon (:), semi-colon (;), or an en dash (-).

8) Words and phrases to avoid:

- We do not shame people (eg. we don't give people a hard time about making excuses). We all have fears, especially about making big changes, and we address those concerns with love and a bit of humor.
- We don't participate in hustle culture! No glorifying overwork and burnout! A good way to gauge this is by asking yourself "Is this advice reasonable for a caretaker?" For example, advice to just work nights and weekends may not be reasonable for someone in charge of kids or family members, and therefore veers into the world of hustle culture.
- We don't talk down or badmouth our competitors. While we write truthful reviews about other coding schools/bootcamps on our blog, we do not use disparaging language or try to make direct comparisons to our own courses. We do talk about what makes Skillcrush special!
- We don't trade being nice and understanding for being truthful. Sometimes we follow up an, "it's okay to be tired" with a "but here's how to get it done when you're ready!"
- We don't sacrifice clarity for creativity. We always want to ensure that our messages are as clear and direct as possible, even if that means cutting out a cute pun or wordplay for the sake of making it easy to understand the message.

Words Not to Use (and What to Use Instead)

Instead of...	Try...
Engineer, Coder, Programmer	Developer, Job in tech, tech job
Software development	Coding, Tech, Development (maybe)
Tech bro lingo (Rockstar, ninja, sexy, unicorn, dude, bro, anything about ping pong and beer...)	Just no, only if you're making fun of it

Implicitly male-gendered/exclusionary words (One man shop, tech guy, guys...)	One person shop, tech worker, y'all
Awesome, Crazy, Insane	Impressive, surprising, next-level, etc., etc.
Language that appropriates cultures (Tribe, pow-wow...)	Just don't!
Techies (use sparingly on the blog, though sometimes appropriate in sales emails that are more chipper in tone)	More specific noun (developers, designers, marketers)
Newbies (use sparingly on the blog, though sometimes appropriate in sales emails that are more chipper in tone)	Beginners, career changers
Computer science	Tech, Digital
"Sorority speak" (dish on, spill the beans, tell all, give you the skinny)	Share, explain, etc.
Bank (as in "make bank"), cash, raking it in, dough	Salary (high salary, great salary), earning power, paycheck, financial freedom
"From the comfort of your couch"	Remotely, from home
Telecommuting	Working from home, working remotely
Unicorn	Unicorn means designer and developer in one! Not someone to do multiple jobs for not much pay.
Womxn	Women
Preferred pronouns	Pronouns

Tips for Skillcrush Writers

- 1) Write like a human, not a brand
 - If it sounds stiff, rewrite it
- 2) Keep sentences short
 - Especially when explaining technical ideas
- 3) Check your facts

- We take great pride in knowing the truth and citing our sources whenever possible.
 - i) Internal links, as well as external ones, should be incorporated and attached to the correct anchor text (see below) without overdoing it. Ideally, one link per ~100 words works. Also, do not exceed more than 100 links on your blog or page in total. In all likelihood, you'll need much fewer than that!
 - ii) When linking, use anchor text wisely and avoid generic anchor text formats, like: "Click here to learn about Skillcrush's courses." Instead, attach your link to relevant keywords or statistics. Ex: "Skillcrush makes careers in tech accessible to everyone." That's true when quoting research and reports, too. Example: "According to the Women in Tech Network, women make up about [35%](#) of the tech workforce."

4) Use the active voice

- Say, "I checked the facts," not, "The facts were checked by me."

5) Fight statistical exaggeration

- Statistics have a way of growing more extreme the more they're shared. Keep yours honest, even if it means they require more explanation.

6) Use examples

- Show what things look like in real life
- Names, backgrounds, career paths, and goals should reflect our community.
 - i) If inventing names, mix them up. Don't just stick to Anglo-Saxon Jacks and Jills.
 - ii) Same with genders and ages.

7) Before you write

- Ask yourself: what is our UNIQUE Skillcrush take on this topic? What do we have to say that no one else has or would say? Write that!



Formatting & Visuals

- Use title case for all headers
- Use H2s and H3s to break up content
- Favor bullet points and numbered lists for scannability
- Keep paragraphs short (1–3 sentences)

- Refer to the [GEO-friendly formatting guide](#) for more specific guidelines on blog formatting

Visuals should:

- Support understanding, not decorate
- Reflect diversity and inclusion
- Feel modern, clean, and approachable

Avoid cluttered layouts or overly stock-photo-y imagery.

SEO & Accessibility Basics

SEO

- Identify a clear target keyword before writing
 - Your keyword should be incorporated within the first 30 words and used both exactly and with variations (which you can find in Semrush) throughout the rest of your text.
 - While keyword stuffing isn't the SEO kryptonite it once was, it's still best to avoid overly cramming in keywords. E.g. in a ~200 word blog intro, using your exact keyword 10 times would be a lot.
- Use the keyword naturally in the title, intro, headers, and body
- Write for humans first, search engines second
- Blog length should ideally be between 1,200 words and 1,500 words

Accessibility

- Use descriptive link text (not "click here")
- Add alt text to images
- Avoid long blocks of dense text
- Explain visuals and charts in the copy

Final Gut Check

- Before submitting, ask: *Does this make tech feel more accessible, more human, and more possible?*
 - If the answer is 'yes', you're doing it right 💜
- After your blog is published, identify other relevant blogs and pages on Skillcrush where this blog could be linked out to, using the target keyword as anchor text.